

The Long Way Home

The windswept shores of Troy stretch along a bright Aegean sea, where wooden ships with painted eyes lie beached on the long sand and a great city of honey-coloured walls stands proud on the hill above. For a long while two camps, the weary seafarers on the beach and the proud city behind its gates, have been caught in a tired old quarrel that neither truly wants. Across the wine-dark sea lies the long road home, full of wonders: a loyal old hound, a keeper of the winds, and lonely sea-singers on the rocks. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is clever, brave, and keeps faith with a friend. The grandest deeds are done not with spears but with a good idea and a kind heart, and the oldest quarrels often end with a single brave act of friendship.



The Long Way Home

Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

The long quarrel was over at last, and it had ended in the most surprising way of all: not with spears or fire, but with friendship. The great honey-coloured gates of Troy stood open in the morning sun, and the two old camps shared their bread like neighbours. Now only one journey remained, the longest of them all. It was time to sail home across the Wine-Dark Sea, all the way back to the Weaving Hall, where a warm fire, a homecoming feast, and old friends had been waiting through all the long years away.

Odysseus the Clever walked the two of you down to where the ships lay beached on the long sand. "It is a long way home," he said, looking out at the wide and restless water, "and the sea keeps its own counsel. But you are clever, you are brave, and you keep faith with your friends, and that is worth more on a voyage than a hold full of treasure."

Into your hands he pressed three gifts for the road: a great spiral Conch Horn that sounded a warm, calling note across the water; a Basket of Honey and Figs to share with any wary stranger; and a ball of strong weaving thread, Penelope's Thread, which always leads a traveller home. "Remember," he said, "out on the wide sea we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being clever, by being brave, and by keeping faith."

What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry on the voyage: Cleverness, Courage, or Loyalty?

Stop 1: The Isle of Winds

You sailed for many days, until one bright morning a strange island rose from the sea ahead, ringed all around with cliffs of shining bronze that floated upon the water as lightly as a cork. This was the Isle of Winds, the home of Aeolus, Keeper of the Winds, who kept every gust and gale of the whole world tied up safely inside a great leather wind-bag.

Aeolus met you with a friendly face, but he was a careful host. He would lend a fair wind, he explained, only to travellers who asked him cleverly and courteously, and who were not greedy enough to go peeking after more than they needed. "Ask me well," he said, with a twinkle, "and give me your word you will never untie the wind-bag to peep inside it. The wind is a gift, not a treasure to be hoarded."

How will you ask Aeolus for a fair wind? Can you find clever, courteous words, and perhaps a promise that you will not peek inside the bag? What is your plan?

When you asked him cleverly and kindly, and gave your word, Aeolus threw back his head and laughed with delight. He gathered a gentle westerly wind in his hands and tied it softly into your sail. "A fair wind for friends who know how to ask," he said, and the bronze cliffs sank away behind you as your ship leapt forward over the waves.

Stop 2: The Singing Sirens

For many quiet days you sailed on, with Aeolus's wind steady at your back. Then, one still afternoon, you heard it drift across the water: a song. It was the most beautiful thing you had ever heard, and also the saddest, a melody so full of longing that it seemed to tug at the very rudder of your ship. It came from the Singing Sirens, the sea-singers who sat upon a circle of lonely rocks, and ship after ship had drifted off course down the years just to follow that aching tune.

But this was no danger to flee from, though your heart might race to hear it. Listen closely. There was no wickedness in that song at all. The Sirens were only lonely, terribly lonely, for in all their long years not one single sailor had ever stopped to be their friend.

This was never a fight, and it was never a race to slip away unseen. What kindness could you offer the Sirens instead? You might sing a warm song back to them across the water. You might sound the Conch Horn so its kindly note reached their rocks. You might share your Basket of Honey and Figs. What do you try?

When you answered their loneliness with kindness, the saddest song in all the sea faltered and changed. The Sirens lifted their heads in wonder, and then they laughed, a sound that had not been heard on those rocks for a hundred years. They sang again, but now their song was bright and glad, and it wound around your ship like a friendly hand and guided you safely through the rocks. "Come back and visit us one day!" they called after you, waving until the rocks were small behind you.

Stop 3: Home at Last

At last, far across the bright water, a low green shore came into view, and something in you went very still and very sure. Was this truly home, after all this time? You leaned over the rail and looked, and looked again, for you had to be certain.

The ship slid up onto a sand you half remembered, and you followed a winding path up from the shore until the Weaving Hall stood before you, just as it always had. Through the open door you could see the great loom standing in the firelight, with a half-finished weaving on it, as though someone had been working there patiently all the while you were gone. An old friend glanced up from beside the loom. And there, curled by the hearth, a grey old dog raised his head and tested the air with his nose.

How will you know, truly know, that you are home? What do you remember of this place? Look for the great loom, for the face of an old friend, for the faithful hound by the fire. Who is it that waits there?

It was Argos the Faithful Hound, who never in all his long life had forgotten a friend or a scent. For a moment he simply stared. Then he scrambled up on his stiff old legs and trotted to you, his tail wagging so hard that the whole of him wagged with it, and you knew, past all doubt, that you were home at last.

Home at Last

The Weaving Hall filled with warmth and golden light. The homecoming feast was laid along the long table: fresh bread still warm from the oven, ripe figs, and clear honey. Old friends threw their arms around you and called you by your hero name, hardly able to believe that the long way home was done. And Argos the Faithful Hound would not be parted from your side, not for one single moment.

Far out over the calm and shining sea, Thetis the Sea-Mother looked up from the gentle waves and smiled. You had crossed the whole wide Wine-Dark Sea, from the windswept shores of Troy to your own warm door, and you had done it together: with your cleverness, with your courage, and above all by keeping faith with one another. Well done, heroes of the windswept shores. Welcome home.

The Story in Pictures



A gentle keeper of the winds on a floating bronze-cliffed island, handing two older heroes a soft leather bag holding a fair wind.



Two older heroes on a small ship near a rocky isle where gentle wistful sea-singers sing, the heroes sounding a conch and singing back kindly, the singers looking lonely rather than frightening.



Two older heroes arriving home at a warm hall across the sea, a great loom in the lamplight and a homecoming feast being laid, old friends rising to greet them.



A joyful homecoming feast in a warm hall, two older heroes reunited with friends and a faithful old hound, a gentle sea goddess smiling through a window of evening light.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Notes

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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